agriculture and water management. With Saudi Arabia, concerted efforts have been made to diversify away from Indian migrant labour to other forms of people-to-people exchanges, including highly skilled workers and Indian students, who now account for a large number of overseas Indians in the country. Saudi Arabia's massive investments in universities, infrastructure, start-ups, and entertainment have significantly widened the potential for economic, business, and people-to-people cooperation with India. The United Arab Emirates has become a major hub in the region for Indian trade, travel, and finance, and is now one of India's most important partners. Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed's visit to India in January 2017 can probably be identified as the critical turning point in India's relationship with the Gulf.

The development and consolidation of new regional partnerships is a natural progression, building upon the long-term changes underway in a post-'Arab Spring' region. After the Abraham Accords normalized relations between Israel, on the one hand, and the UAE, Bahrain, Morocco, and other Arab states on the other, India welcomed the move and established a dialogue focused on economic issues with the United States, Israel, and UAE, called I2U2. [25] Starting with specific projects focused on renewable energy and food security, the group has attempted to deepen their partnership by facilitating business contacts and cooperating on space and other technologies. A bigger bet involves the IMEC, which promises to develop port, rail, road, digital, and hydrogen infrastructure between India and Saudi Arabia, and eventually connect it to Israel and Europe. [26] This infrastructure could service key economies along the way, making it more sustainable than some other major connectivity initiatives. It would also build resilience given the vulnerabilities of regional chokepoints such as the Suez Canal and Bab-el-Mandeb.

While initiatives such as I2U2 and IMEC can be built upon further, potentially reshaping the region, India will have to remain cognizant of other important relationships. These will extend to Iran, which is functionally less useful, but still important given cultural connections and north–south connectivity (including from the Indian Ocean to Central Asia